the close-packed Flemish foot soldiers until the ranks broke and fled. The Flemish captain was found dead in a ditch without a wound on him; he had been trampled and suffocated by the masses of men climbing across him.[8]

High on triumph, Charles returned to Paris. The residents came out to greet him in arms, determined to show their new young king just how much power they had; in response, Charles ordered his captains to remove the gates from the city and clear the streets, so that he could stampede the entire army into the city to put down any further rebellion. This proved adequately terrifying: the Parisians slunk back into their homes, "so fearful of being punished," Froissart says, "that, as the King entered the city, none dared to venture out of doors, or even to open a window." In retaliation, Charles VI and his advisors levied heavy fines on those who had protested publicly: "as a punishment for their past behavior, and as an example to other towns in the kingdom of France."[9]

RICHARD II was given no better guidance.

The logical regent for the underage king was his uncle John of Gaunt, the oldest surviving son of Edward III. But John was widely disliked, and more than one courtier suspected that he had designs on the English throne. Instead, a governing council was formed; its membership varied from year to year, but all, says the *Chronica Maiora,* were "good, sensible men of repute."[10]

They may have been good, but their decisions were bad ones. To raise money for the ongoing war with France, the king's council orchestrated a series of new taxes: "poll taxes," flat payments imposed on everyone in the country. The first of these, collected in 1377, required each person in England to pay one groat—a coin roughly equivalent to the price of a goat (the tax was slightly higher for clergymen). The second, passed in 1379, required a groat from the poor, but much more from knights and landowners. It was a "subsidy so wonderful that no one had ever seen or heard of the like," groused the fourteenth-century *Anonimalle Chronicle*—unprecedented and wildly unpopular.[11]

In December of 1380, a third "wonderful subsidy" was proposed: three groats from every man and woman in England over the age of fifteen. Triple the first tax, the 1380 poll tax was levied equally all across the country; peasants were called on to pay exactly the same amount as John of Gaunt and the Mayor of London.*

As tax collection began, in the spring of 1381, tax collectors noticed something odd. Five hundred thousand or so laborers, shepherds, and farmers seemed to have simply disappeared from England since 1377. Devon was particularly afflicted by this strange vanishing-peasant phenomenon.